Why Some People Hear Music That Is Not Playing

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Almost everyone has had a song stuck in their head. But some people hear music that sounds as real as a song on the radio, even when nothing is playing. Scientists call these **musical** hallucinations**.**

A **hallucination** is when the brain senses something that is not really there. **Musical** hallucinations **are sometimes linked to** hearing loss**. One idea is that when the brain's sound area gets less information from the ears, it pulls music from** memory **instead.**

A new study looked at 80 people who hear music that is not there. Most were older adults, with an **average** age of 65.

Most of the songs they heard were older songs, not new hits. Religious songs were the most common. Earlier research found many were holiday or children's songs. This suggests the brain reaches back to tunes people learned when they were young.

Only about one in five people could control the music. The researchers hope that explaining the science will help people feel comfortable asking for help.

Word Treasure

musical hallucinations -- Hearing music that seems real even though nothing is playing.
hallucination -- When the brain senses something that is not really there.
hearing loss -- When a person cannot hear as well as before.
memory -- The brain's way of saving things you have learned or experienced.
average -- A number that shows what is typical for a group.

Background you need

Our ears pick up sounds, and our brain figures out what those sounds are.

The brain also stores songs and other memories, sometimes for a whole lifetime.

Scientists study unusual brain experiences so they can understand them and help people.

Break it down

WHO: 80 people, mostly older adults, who hear music that is not there
WHAT: A new study looked at why some people hear music that is not playing
WHERE: Inside people's brains, where the music seems to come from memory
WHY: When the brain gets less information from the ears, it may pull music from memory

Why it matters

Learning how the brain works helps people understand themselves and feel okay asking for help when something feels strange.

Test what you remember

1. What do scientists call hearing music that is not playing?

- (A) Radio waves
- (B) Echo songs
- (C) Sound bubbles
- (D) Musical hallucinations

2. What is a hallucination?

- (A) A hearing test
- (B) A loud noise
- (C) When the brain senses something that is not really there
- (D) A kind of song

3. What are musical hallucinations sometimes linked to?

- (A) Playing sports
- (B) Eating candy
- (C) Cold weather
- (D) Hearing loss

4. How many people did the new study look at?

- (A) 8
- (B) 8,000
- (C) 800
- (D) 80

5. What kind of songs did people mostly hear?

- (A) Older songs
- (B) No songs at all
- (C) Only rap songs
- (D) Brand-new hits

6. How many people could control the music?

- (A) Everyone
- (B) Half
- (C) About one in five
- (D) Nobody

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: D 4: D 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):